popular single attraction in the country, closely followed by two nearby Mughal sites: the Agra Fort and the Red Fort[43]. Studies of these visitors show that not only are they diverse in their national origin, but also in the ways that they interpret the importance and meaning of the site. While it is true that most interpret the site along the popular "symbol of love" narrative, others see it as a symbol of Muslim power and still others as an emblem of a lost colonial era.[44] These symbolic perspectives also take on new flavors as they are continually adopted and twisted about in new circumstances. For example, in 1992, Princess Diana visited the Taj and had a number of solitary photos taken of her on a bench. As her marriage to Prince Charles was disintegrating in a very public way at the time, her solitude in the world's preeminent symbol of royal loneliness and lost love became instantly famous[45].

At the same time, the Taj also remains a pre-eminent symbol of India, as evidenced by the innumerable Indian restaurants around the globe named for it (perhaps rivaled only by the number of Chinese restaurants named for the Great Wall), its appearances on packages of frozen Indian food, not to mention endless amounts of tourist kitsch. In contrast to these commercialized uses of the site, the ASI has done its best to fight commercialization, specifically because of the site's importance as a national symbol not to be appropriated by brands. As a result, the ASI forbids all sorts of promotional uses and forbids product placement and advertising photo shoots at the site. In 2013, the ASI even lodged a police complaint against the reigning Miss Universe, Olivia Culpo, when she smuggled shoes she was advertising into the site and had photos taken of her in them in front of the building[46].

Despite its close association with India, or perhaps because of it, the fact that what is easily India's most famous structure was built by a Muslim dynasty and not an indigenous Hindu one rankles the Hindu far-right. This conservative movement, called "Hindutva," has sought to denigrate, minimize or outright erase the presence of Muslims in Northern India, both in the present day and also in the historic and architectural record. The most shocking example of this was when an anti-Muslim mob literally tore apart the Mughal Babri Mosque in Ayodhya, claiming that it was built on the site of an earlier Hindu temple to the god Ram. This led to religious strife and riots throughout India that resulted in the deaths of hundreds.